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# Shorter Working Week Pilot: Review of Findings

Linden Group Claims Contact Team

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## Summary

Between February 5 and March 29, 2024, 18 advisers in the Linden Group Claims Contact Team tried a 36-hour week over four days, with no change to salary. The pilot lasted eight weeks. We asked team leaders and advisers how the change affected productivity, and we checked the customer complaints log.

## Key findings

- Team leaders rated adviser productivity higher at the end of the pilot (average 3.8 out of 5, up from 3.4).
- Advisers rated their own productivity higher too (3.9, up from 3.5).
- Complaints fell from 6.1 to 5.2 for every 1,000 customer contacts.
- We did not collect reliable call waiting times during the pilot, so we cannot report on them.
- The Executive Committee will consider these findings.

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## 1. Why we ran the pilot

The Claims Contact Team handles first notifications of loss and answers questions from customers who have made an insurance claim. Contact is by telephone and by email, from 8 AM to 6 PM, Monday to Friday. Before the pilot, advisers worked five days a week for 37.5 hours.

The People and Culture Team wanted to find out whether a shorter week could improve how advisers felt about work without making customer service worse.

## 2. How we ran it

**Who took part.** All 18 advisers in the team took part. Two advisers were on long-term leave for most of the period, so the results below cover 16 advisers.<sup>1</sup>

**Length.** The pilot ran for eight weeks, from February 5 to March 29, 2024.

**Working pattern.** Advisers worked four 9-hour days (36 hours) instead of five days (37.5 hours). Salaries did not change. Advisers chose their day off from a list, and no more than four advisers could choose the same day.

### What we measured.

- Productivity was measured by asking the six team leaders to rate each adviser's overall productivity from 1 (very low) to 5 (very high) at the start and at the end of the pilot. Advisers also rated themselves on the same scale.
- Customer service was measured with the complaints log: complaints for every 1,000 customer contacts.
- We planned to record call waiting times, but the recording was not kept consistently, so we do not report them.

### 3. What we found

Table 1 shows the main results for the 16 advisers covered by the analysis.

**Table 1: Results at the start and end of the pilot**

| Measure                                                | Start of pilot | End of pilot | Change |
|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------|--------------|--------|
| Team leader rating of productivity (average, 1 to 5)   | 3.4            | 3.8          | +0.4   |
| Advisers rated the same or higher by their team leader | -              | 14 of 16     | -      |
| Adviser self-rating of productivity (average, 1 to 5)  | 3.5            | 3.9          | +0.4   |
| Complaints for every 1,000 customer contacts           | 6.1            | 5.2          | -0.9   |

**Notes to Table 1.**

<sup>1</sup> Excludes two advisers who were on long-term leave for most of the pilot.

<sup>2</sup> Team leaders knew which advisers were taking part in the pilot when they gave their ratings. Ratings are opinions and were not checked against call or claim data.

<sup>3</sup> The pilot period did not include a seasonal peak in claims.

Team leaders gave higher ratings to most advisers at the end of the pilot. Fourteen of the 16 advisers were rated the same or higher.<sup>2</sup> Advisers rated themselves higher, too.

The complaints rate fell from 6.1 to 5.2 for every 1,000 contacts. Most of the complaints we reviewed were about the speed of claim updates. We did not find a link between the pilot and any particular type of complaint.

### 4. What advisers said

In the end-of-pilot survey, most advisers said they felt more rested and more able to concentrate. A few said the nine-hour days were tiring, especially in the last hour of the day. Two advisers said they would prefer to return to five shorter days.

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## 5. Limits of this review

- The pilot was short, at eight weeks, and ran in one team.
- Productivity was based on ratings and not on measured output. The ratings were given by people who knew who was in the pilot.<sup>2</sup>
- We did not measure call waiting times, so we cannot say whether callers waited longer.
- The pilot did not include a busy season.<sup>3</sup>
- We did not compare the team with a similar team that kept a five-day week.

## 6. Next steps

The People and Culture Team will present these findings to the Executive Committee. The Committee will consider whether to carry out a longer pilot, with better measures of waiting times and productivity.

## About this review

This review was written by the People and Culture Team at Linden Group. The team ran the pilot and wrote this review. Questions can be sent to the team.